

MBA Programmes

Dissertation Process Handbook

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ROBERT KENNEDY COLLEGE
swiss quality education

Est.
1841

YORK
ST JOHN
UNIVERSITY

Abstract

This document is meant to provide quick and easy access to the basic features, rules, and otherwise important information concerning the functioning of the MBA dissertation.

Person responsible for maintaining this document: radu.negoescu@rkc.edu.

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1 Overview of the dissertation

1.1 Components of the dissertation

The dissertation stands for 60 credits out of a total of 180 credits for the MBA award, and it is encapsulated in a module called MBK7011M Research Methods and Dissertation. It is composed of two marked pieces of work:

1. the dissertation proposal - a 2,000 words document, marked on the 0-100 scale, weighted at 20% of the overall module mark
2. the dissertation - a 12,000 words document, which may include parts of the proposal at no risk of self-plagiarism, marked on the 0-100 scale, weighted at 80% of the overall module mark

NB: for all documents the standard University policy on over-length work applies (leeway of 10% on the word count).

In order to achieve the 60 credits, the student needs to obtain an overall module mark of at least 50. A pass mark in each individual component is not a requirement.

As a pre-requisite of the dissertation module, students must attend a residency in either York or Zürich, where they are exposed to fundamentals of research methods (quantitative / qualitative method, analysing data, bias, ethical considerations, etc.) and develop initial ideas for the content.

A second pre-requisite is having achieved 120 credits, of which at most 30 under the compensation scheme (a fail mark in the 45-49 range). In other words, at most one failed module, with a marginal fail mark.

1.2 Timelines for the dissertation

The overall timeframe for the dissertation is **30 weeks**. These are split as follows:

- Proposal - 6 weeks
- Dissertation - 24 weeks

The students can submit their final version for marking before the final deadline, but not sooner than 5 months (or 21 weeks).

2 Assigning a supervisor

After the residency, students have access to a peer-support forum, where they can continue the exchange of ideas amongst themselves. Students are then presented with a questionnaire that asks them about general areas of interest for the dissertation, research question and objectives, preliminary ideas for research methodology. The deadline to fill this questionnaire is **two (2) weeks before the start of the dissertation module** that they signed up for.

After the questionnaire is completed, a supervisor is actively searched for by the RKC Dissertation Coordinators, and is allocated to the student before the start of the module.

3 Guidelines for supervision

3.1 Privacy and confidentiality of submitted work

Students should be encouraged on every occasion to remove any direct references to persons or organisations that may lead to their being recognised.

In addition to this, work submitted to RKC and YSJU may not be used by RKC and YSJU outside the grading process without the express consent of the student, but confidentiality cannot be guaranteed. It is assumed that the student has obtained any necessary permission to study an organisation/person(s).

3.2 Interaction guidelines

Students can expect regular contact with their supervisor but supervisors are not expected to respond instantly either to emails or uploads to the Thesis Repository. A delay of up to a week is acceptable, after which a student may contact the supervisor to see if there is any special reason for the delay. If the delay continues for two weeks, the student may contact Ruth Chandy who can investigate.

Students and supervisors should note that while email and even Skype contact are of course acceptable forms of communication, the principal point of contact should be the Thesis Repository which provides a consistent and reliable audit trail.

3.3 Proposal - 6 weeks

The student and supervisor work together for up to 6 weeks in defining the proposal. By the end of that period, a formal proposal must have been submitted by the student for assessment. It is expected that at least one draft proposal be submitted via the Thesis Repository before the final document is uploaded.

3.3.1 Research Ethics

Students have access to the Research Ethics Form (REF) in the Dissertation module syllabus - this checklist should be completed for every research project. It is used to identify whether a full application for ethics approval needs to be submitted.

3.3.2 Research Ethics Approval

The completed RSF must be submitted via the Thesis Repository during the proposal stage, and seen by the supervisor. If both the supervisor and an ethics panel in RKC are happy that there are no ethical issues, the research can proceed. Research forms are also sampled by the ethics panel in YSJU.

3.3.3 The Research Ethics Full Approval

If there are any doubts about ethical issues raised by the proposed research, or if the answer to any of the screening questions warrants a full ethical approval request, then the Research Ethics Form will be reviewed by an Ethics panel at the University. No research should be carried out (data collection in particular) until full approval is received.

3.4 Dissertation - minimum 15 weeks, maximum 24 weeks

After the formal proposal is submitted for marking, the student and supervisor continue working together towards the dissertation - this may include final changes to the proposal before diving into the research per se. The students should upload drafts via the Thesis Repository, on a schedule agreed with the supervisor - these provide not only an audit trail, but also intermediary back-ups!

3.5 Grading process and turnaround times

3.5.1 Proposal stage

Proposals are marked by a team of proposal-markers, in order to ensure quick turnaround times - it is expected that not more than 7 days would be needed for each of the markers to process 10 proposals. The supervisor will assign a suggested mark to the proposal as soon as practicable (without a formal report). The aim of this suggested mark is to identify different views. There is a week's discussion time window during which the supervisor and marker may discuss their views, but ultimately the markers' marks stand.

Failure in the proposal In case of failure in the proposal, the student has a choice of whether to resubmit it or not, for a capped mark. Since the proposal is weighted at 20% of the full mark, it may be possible to obtain an overall pass mark without resubmitting. It is however recommended that the student resubmits the proposal, not only from a marking point of view, but also to ensure the best start towards the dissertation. The proposal resubmission process does not extend the dissertation deadline.

3.5.2 Dissertation stage

Dissertations are first marked by the supervisor, and simultaneously blind marked by the 2nd marker. The timeframe for the marking process is 4

weeks, with 3 weeks normally allocated for marking, and one extra week reserved for reaching an agreed mark. In case of agreement, the supervisor writes the student feedback report to match the agreed mark (incorporating 2nd marker points), and then the mark and feedback are sent for moderation to YSJ.

After moderation, the supervisor ensures the feedback matches the moderated mark, and marks are released to the students.

Failure in the dissertation A failure in the 80% component of the module (the dissertation) will generally lead to a failed module. In such cases, the student is given an opportunity to resubmit the dissertation within 30 weeks (7 months). There is an additional fee of 1200 CHF to be paid in the event of resubmission.

3.5.3 Overview of dissertation process and its timings

Event	Time frame	Responsibility
Duration of MBK7011M	30 weeks	Admin team
Student proposal deadline	6 weeks	student
Proposal mark deadline	14 days	team of proposal-markers
Proposal mark discussion	7 days	supervisor/marker
Proposal mark moderation deadline	7 days	moderator
Student dissertation deadline	24 weeks	student
Dissertation double marking deadline	4 weeks	Supervisor / 2nd marker
Dissertation moderation deadline	2 weeks	moderator